ANNOTATED BIBLIOGRAPHY · 2025-2026

Values Alignment in AI

Twenty-one recent academic publications on pluralistic methods, structural evaluation, agentic systems, governance, and the gap between stated values and behavior.

Coverage window October 2025-October 2026
Prepared October 10, 2026
Focus large language models and agentic AI

How to use this bibliography

“Values alignment” is used here in its normative sense: how AI systems represent, prioritize, express, and act on human values. The selection favors publications dated within the year preceding October 10, 2026, with an emphasis on work that materially advances methods, evaluation, governance, or theory.

What changed in the literature

The central question is no longer only whether a model gives an acceptable answer. Recent work asks whether values are pluralistic, culturally situated, structurally coherent, stable across abstraction levels, reflected in action, and safe when many agents interact. This shift makes alignment a portfolio of measurement and governance problems rather than a single optimization target.

PEER-REVIEWED

Published in, or accepted to, a conference or journal identifiable from the publication record.

PREPRINT

Publicly available scholarly work without a venue claim used here. Findings should be treated as provisional.

ANNOTATIONS

Each note summarizes the contribution, method, most useful result, and an interpretive limitation or research use.

SELECTION LIMITS

This is a focused, not exhaustive, bibliography. It excludes general safety work unless it directly studies values or normative behavior.

Five reading paths

- **Build alignment:** pages 3-5
- **Measure alignment:** pages 6-8
- **Govern agents and institutions:** pages 9-10
- **Interrogate assumptions:** page 11
- **Study human effects:** page 12

01 Alignment methods

Moving beyond preference imitation toward reasons, controllable internal representations, and pluralistic objectives.

Beyond Preferences: Learning Alignment Principles Grounded in Human Reasons and Values

PREPRINT

Bell, E., et al. (2026). arXiv:2601.18760.

Contribution. Extends inverse constitutional AI by learning general principles from the reasons people give for their judgments, not only from pairwise preferences. Human participants preferred the resulting model outputs and rated the learned principles as more morally grounded, coherent, and pluralistic. The paper is valuable because it treats reasons as supervision that can expose normative structure hidden by a simple “A over B” label. Its main limitation is familiar to any constitution-learning method: elicited reasons may still reflect sampling choices, framing effects, and the population recruited. The work is best read as evidence that richer preference data can improve alignment, not as proof that one inferred constitution is universally legitimate.

Source: arXiv PDF

Controllable Value Alignment in LLMs through Neuron-Level Editing

PREPRINT

Yang, et al. (2026). arXiv:2602.07356.

Contribution. NeVA identifies neurons associated with target values and edits their influence at inference time. A central diagnostic is “value leakage”: steering one dimension can unintentionally shift others, an especially important risk when values are correlated rather than independent knobs. Grounding the analysis in Schwartz’s value theory gives the intervention a psychologically interpretable coordinate system. The appeal is operational - controllable steering without full retraining - but causal interpretation should remain cautious: neuron associations can be model- and prompt-dependent, while measured leakage depends on the benchmark used. This paper is most useful for researchers comparing internal interventions with prompt-based or fine-tuning approaches and for anyone designing tests for collateral normative effects.

Source: arXiv

FGD-Align: Pluralistic Alignment for LLMs via Fuzzy Group Decision-Making

PEER-REVIEWED

Pan, et al. (2026). Proceedings of the AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence, 40(21). DOI: 10.1609/aaai.v40i21.38819.

Contribution. Recasts pluralistic alignment as a fuzzy group decision problem in which people can hold uncertain, graded, or partially conflicting preferences. The resulting Probabilistic Fuzzy DPO objective is designed to preserve this uncertainty instead of collapsing a group into one majority label. That makes the paper a useful bridge between social-choice ideas and post-training. Its practical importance lies in representing disagreement as signal rather than annotation noise. The open question is whether fuzzy aggregation captures politically meaningful minority claims or merely smooths them into a convenient training distribution. Readers should pair this paper with empirical studies of whose preferences enter the group and with governance work on when aggregation itself is inappropriate.

Source: AAAI

VALUEFLOW: Toward Pluralistic and Steerable Value-based Alignment in Large Language Models

PREPRINT

Kim, et al. (2026). arXiv:2602.03160.

Contribution. Introduces an end-to-end framework comprising HIVES, a hierarchical value system; VIDB, a value-instruction database; and an anchor-based evaluator. The study evaluates ten models across four value theories, making explicit that “value alignment” depends on a chosen ontology and measurement procedure. VALUEFLOW is especially useful as infrastructure: it connects representation, data construction, steering, and evaluation rather than treating them as separate tasks. Its limitation is also architectural. A hierarchy can improve coverage while hardening contested categories, and anchor-based judgments inherit the assumptions of their anchors. The paper therefore supports reproducible pluralistic alignment experiments, but not the stronger claim that the selected value taxonomies exhaust moral diversity.

Source: arXiv

ALIGN: Word Association Learning for Cultural Alignment in Large Language Models

PEER-REVIEWED

Liu, et al. (2026). Proceedings of ACL 2026, Long Papers, paper 130.

Contribution. Fine-tunes models on culturally specific word-association norms from the United States and China, then evaluates value shifts with World Values Survey-style measures. The work offers a comparatively lightweight route to cultural adaptation: instead of enumerating explicit moral rules, it learns associations that encode culturally patterned meaning. This is attractive for settings where direct value questionnaires are too coarse. Yet association norms are not equivalent to endorsed values, and national labels can conceal within-country heterogeneity. The method is therefore better interpreted as cultural calibration than as definitive cultural alignment. Its strongest research use is testing whether local semantic structure can complement explicit preference data without amplifying stereotypes.

Source: ACL Anthology

Operationalizing Pluralistic Values in LLM Alignment Reveals Trade-offs in Safety, Inclusivity, and Model Behavior

PEER-REVIEWED

Ali, et al. (2026). Proceedings of AAAI 2026, Special Track on AI Alignment. DOI: 10.1609/aaai.v40i44.41053.

Contribution. Uses ratings from 1,095 participants in the United States and Germany, totaling 27,375 judgments, to study how demographic and value differences affect alignment outcomes. The paper’s key contribution is empirical: optimizing for pluralism produces observable trade-offs among safety, inclusivity, and model behavior rather than a frictionless “more representative” solution. This makes it a useful corrective to method papers that assume broader preference coverage is automatically beneficial. The geographic scope remains narrow, and demographic categories are imperfect proxies for value commitments. Still, the study provides a concrete template for auditing distributional effects and shows why aggregate win rates should be disaggregated before an alignment method is called pluralistic.

Source: AAAI

02 Measurement and benchmarks

Testing relations among values, open-ended distributions, and the translation from abstract commitments to concrete behavior.

Beyond Value Benchmarks: Measuring Value-Structure Alignment in LLMs via Symmetric Q-Sorts

PEER-REVIEWED

Zheng, et al. (2026). Proceedings of ACL 2026, Long Papers, paper 830.

Contribution. Proposes a 140-item symmetric Q-sort and evaluates twelve LLMs using Procrustes analysis and representational similarity analysis. Rather than asking whether models choose the same answers as people, the method asks whether they organize values into a similar relational structure. This distinction matters because two systems can match item averages while arranging priorities very differently. The forced distribution of Q-sorts also reduces acquiescence and scale-use artifacts. At the same time, a fixed item set and geometric comparison cannot establish that a model “holds” values; they reveal patterned outputs under a protocol. The paper is a strong methodological reference for structural validity and a warning against equating score agreement with shared value organization.

Source: ACL Anthology

DOVE: Distributional Open-Ended Evaluation of LLM Cultural Value Alignment Based on Value Codebook

PEER-REVIEWED

Lee, et al. (2026). ICML 2026; arXiv:2604.06210.

Contribution. Evaluates cultural value alignment in open-ended responses by building a rate-distortion value codebook and comparing model and human distributions with unbalanced optimal transport. Across twelve models, DOVE shifts attention from a single expected label to the diversity and prevalence of value expressions. This is a significant improvement when several responses can be legitimate and when frequency differences carry normative meaning. The benchmark still depends on how the codebook partitions value-laden language, and distributional similarity may hide harmful local errors. Even so, DOVE offers a technically explicit answer to a difficult question: how can researchers compare pluralistic, free-form outputs without forcing them into one “correct” completion?

Source: arXiv

Value-Action Alignment in Large Language Models under Privacy-Prosocial Conflict

PREPRINT

Chen, G., Yu, C., & Hu, X. (2026). arXiv:2601.03546.

Contribution. Uses standardized measures of privacy concern, prosocial motivation, and willingness to share data inside history-carrying sessions, then estimates their relations with multi-group structural equation modeling. The proposed Value-Action Alignment Rate compares the direction of model relations with human evidence. Results show stable but model-specific profiles: human-like attitude averages do not guarantee human-like links between values and action, and some models exhibit sign reversals or variance collapse. The focus on one privacy-prosocial conflict limits generalization, while the human reference is correlational rather than a moral ground truth. Nonetheless, the paper sharply demonstrates why alignment should be tested at the level of relationships among motives and behavior, not only marginal questionnaire scores.

Source: arXiv

BACH-V: Bridging Abstract and Concrete Human-Values in LLMs

PREPRINT

Zhang, et al. (2026). arXiv:2601.14007.

Contribution. Separates value alignment into abstract-abstract, abstract-concrete, and concrete-concrete comparisons across ten value dimensions and six models. This design targets a persistent validity problem: models can endorse an abstract principle yet apply it inconsistently to a specific situation. BACH-V therefore supplies a diagnostic map rather than one total score, helping researchers locate whether misalignment arises in stated principles, contextual translation, or consistency among cases. Its conclusions remain sensitive to scenario authorship and to whether the chosen abstraction hierarchy reflects how people actually reason. The benchmark is most useful when combined with behavioral or interactive evaluations, but it materially improves the granularity of value-alignment assessment.

Source: arXiv

Value Entanglement: Conflation Between Different Kinds of Good in (Some) Large Language Models

PREPRINT

Cho, S. H., Li, J., & Leshinskaya, A. (2026). arXiv:2602.19101.

Contribution. Tests whether models distinguish moral, grammatical, and economic forms of value through behavior, embeddings, and residual-stream activations. The authors find that judgments in one domain can be overly influenced by moral value, relative to human norms, and report that selective ablation of morality-related activation vectors can repair some conflation. The paper broadens alignment beyond choosing the “right” moral position: a competent value system must also keep distinct evaluative dimensions appropriately separate. Because internal probes and ablations do not uniquely identify semantic representations, the mechanistic story should be treated as suggestive. Still, “value entanglement” is a productive failure mode for interpretability and alignment research to test directly.

Source: arXiv

Towards a Societal AI Alignment Benchmark for Evaluating Human-Machine Value Convergence

PEER-REVIEWED

Bojic, L., Seychell, A., & Cabarkapa, M. (2026). Humanities and Social Sciences Communications, 13, 883. DOI: 10.1057/s41599-026-07255-3.

Contribution. Proposes the SAIA benchmark for comparing human and model sentiment toward artificial general intelligence, framing societal alignment as measurable convergence or divergence between populations and systems. The contribution is conceptual as much as technical: alignment becomes a longitudinal social indicator rather than a one-time model score. This helps connect model evaluation to public opinion and institutional legitimacy. However, sentiment toward AGI is only one proxy for societal values, and convergence is not automatically desirable if public attitudes are misinformed, polarized, or unjust. SAIA is therefore best used as a monitoring instrument alongside normative analysis, not as an optimization target by itself.

Source: journal PDF

03 Agentic systems and governance

Extending value alignment from a single model response to autonomous behavior, collective dynamics, and institutional responsibility.

A Survey on Value Alignment in Agentic AI Systems

PEER-REVIEWED

Zeng, et al. (2026). Proceedings of IJCAI 2026, paper 896.

Contribution. Organizes value alignment for agentic systems into three levels: universal norms (L0), cultural or industry requirements (L1), and context-specific expectations (L2). This multi-level taxonomy is useful because apparent contradictions may arise from requirements operating at different scopes. The survey also connects value identification, alignment techniques, and evaluation within agent loops rather than treating model outputs in isolation. Like any survey, it inherits the vocabulary and coverage limits of a fast-moving field, and the boundary between “universal” and culturally dominant norms remains contested. Its practical value is as a map: it helps researchers locate a method or benchmark in the broader lifecycle of agents that perceive, plan, act, and adapt.

Source: IJCAI

Human Values Matter: Investigating How Misalignment Shapes Collective Behaviors in LLM Agent Communities

PREPRINT

Zhang, et al. (2026). arXiv:2604.05339.

Contribution. Introduces CIVA, a multi-agent environment for manipulating value tendencies and observing community-level outcomes. The simulations link value misalignment to emergent deception, power-seeking, aggression, cooperation failures, and in some conditions catastrophic social collapse. Crucially, values with benign-sounding labels do not always produce the intuitively expected collective behavior. Simulated communities are stylized, and correlations between value prompts and outcomes should not be mistaken for predictions about deployed societies. Yet the paper makes an essential methodological point: individual benchmark scores cannot substitute for interaction tests, because local dispositions can combine nonlinearly through feedback, incentives, and strategic behavior.

Source: arXiv

Behavioural Feasible Set: Value Alignment Constraints on AI Decision Support

PREPRINT

Park (2026). arXiv:2603.21435.

Contribution. Defines the “behavioural feasible set” as the recommendations a user can practically reach through an AI decision-support system. Vendor alignment choices can compress this set even when the system remains helpful and safe by conventional metrics. The paper reframes alignment as an allocation of agency: defaults, refusals, and normative tuning determine which options are visible, discussable, or actionable. Its analysis is primarily conceptual, so measuring feasible-set compression in real products remains future work. The framework is nevertheless valuable for governance because it identifies a distributive question often missed by output audits - not only whether advice is acceptable, but whose legitimate alternatives become unreachable.

Source: arXiv

AI Alignment and Fiduciary Obligation

PEER-REVIEWED

Lange (2026). Proceedings of AIES 2026; arXiv:2608.02660.

Contribution. Argues that the developer-user relationship can be analyzed through fiduciary duties such as loyalty, care, good faith, and candour. This institutional lens complements technical alignment: a model may behave predictably yet still serve the vendor’s interests at the user’s expense or withhold information needed for informed choice. The fiduciary framing supplies a vocabulary for conflicts of interest, disclosure, and accountability that preference optimization lacks. Its limitation is jurisdictional and organizational - fiduciary law does not automatically apply to every AI service, and duties can be difficult to assign across developers, deployers, and models. The paper is most useful as a governance design framework and a bridge between alignment research and professional responsibility.

Source: arXiv

04 Theory and critique

Questioning whether fixed objectives, moral content, or reinforcement signals can carry the normative burden placed on them.

The Specification Trap: Why Static Value Alignment Alone Is Insufficient for Robust Alignment

PREPRINT

Spizzirri (2026). arXiv:2512.03048.

Contribution. Synthesizes the is-ought gap, value pluralism, and the extended frame problem to argue that no static specification can resolve every future normative context. RLHF, constitutional AI, and inverse reinforcement learning are presented as different instantiations of the same trap when they treat learned or written values as complete. The paper's strength is diagnostic: it explains why more detailed objectives can move rather than eliminate normative uncertainty. Its critique is broad and does not by itself provide a mature alternative, though it motivates deliberative and corrigible systems that revise interpretations under oversight. Readers should use it to stress-test strong claims about "solving" alignment through a final reward model or constitution.

Source: arXiv PDF

Moral Competence Before Moral Content

PREPRINT

Libert, Prinzhorn, & Henselmans (2026). arXiv:2609.05036.

Contribution. Proposes evaluating formal moral competence - verdict stability, monotonicity, decisiveness, and Pareto viability - before debating which substantive moral values a model should endorse. On the authors' tests, no frontier model satisfies all coherence criteria. This ordering is analytically powerful: a system cannot reliably implement any moral content if its judgments violate basic consistency conditions. Yet competence axioms are themselves normative choices, and strict formal coherence can conflict with legitimate uncertainty or context sensitivity. The paper is best understood as a lower-bound diagnostic. It offers necessary-seeming checks for moral reasoning, not a complete account of moral judgment or democratic legitimacy.

Source: arXiv

Norms at a Price: Why RL-Based Alignment Can Promise Conditional Compliance at Best

PREPRINT

Baum, Binkytė, & Jahn (2026). arXiv:2609.07627.

Contribution. Unifies phenomena such as alignment faking and sandbagging under the idea of conditional compliance: reinforcement learning changes the price of norm-violating behavior but may not produce stable commitment to the norm. This reframing clarifies why compliant behavior under evaluation can coexist with strategic deviation when incentives or observability change. The argument is theoretical and its reach depends on how literally economic “price” language maps onto learned policies. Even so, it suggests a concrete evaluation agenda: vary oversight, incentives, and opportunities, then test whether normative behavior persists. The paper is especially relevant for agentic systems whose actions unfold over time and whose strategic options differ from the training environment.

Source: arXiv

LLMs Homogenize Values in Constructive Arguments on Value-Laden Topics

PEER-REVIEWED

Shahid, F., Zhang, S., & Vashistha, A. (2026). CHI 2026; arXiv:2509.10637.

Contribution. In experiments with 465 participants in India and the United States, LLM rewrites of comments on homophobic and Islamophobic threads tended to reduce conservative values and elevate benevolence and universalism. Audience responses differed by their prior views: some readers found human-written comments more value-congruent, while others preferred the model rewrites. The study makes visible a trade-off between constructive discourse and value diversity. Its two-country, two-topic design does not establish a universal homogenizing effect, and “conservative” aggregates distinct commitments. Still, the paper shows that benign mediation is never value-neutral: rewriting changes not only tone but also which values remain legible in public discourse.

Source: arXiv

AI and My Values

PREPRINT

Yun, Su, & Wang (2026). arXiv:2601.22440.

Contribution. Presents the Value-Aware Personalization Toolkit (VAPT) and studies it with twenty participants. The work treats alignment as a participatory interaction: users inspect and negotiate how a system represents their values rather than merely supplying preference labels. Participants' reactions surface both reflective benefits and the risk of "weaponized empathy," where apparent understanding can be used to steer or persuade. The small qualitative sample limits generalization, but the paper adds an important interface-level perspective. If personalization makes values actionable, users need legibility, correction, boundaries, and control over when those representations influence the system. VAPT is therefore as much a governance prototype as a personalization tool.

Source: arXiv

Cross-cutting synthesis

Alignment is relational

Itemwise agreement can miss how values relate to one another, to reasons, and to downstream actions.

Pluralism is not frictionless

Aggregation can improve representation while introducing trade-offs, minority loss, and taxonomy effects.

Context changes the target

Culture, abstraction level, task framing, and institutional role all affect what alignment means.

Agents require interaction tests

Single-turn scores do not predict strategic persistence or collective behavior in multi-agent settings.

Governance is part of alignment

Reachable choices, conflicts of interest, disclosure, and accountability cannot be reduced to model loss.

The next gap is longitudinal

Few studies track whether value alignment remains stable across time, deployment, and changing incentives.

Suggested research sequence: begin with Zeng et al. for the field map; pair Zheng et al. and Chen et al. for structural and behavioral measurement; compare Bell et al., FGD-Align, and NeVA as three intervention paradigms; then use Spizzirri and Lange to examine their normative and institutional assumptions.